

Pregnancy and Arthritis: What UK Guidelines Recommend

Many DMARDs are unsafe in pregnancy — planning ahead is crucial.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Pending clinical review ·
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Overview



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Many DMARDs are unsafe in pregnancy — planning ahead is crucial.

What the evidence shows

UK guidance from NICE, the British Society for Rheumatology and Arthritis UK consistently emphasises a combined approach: appropriate medication, regular movement, and supportive lifestyle changes. Recent reviews continue to back this consensus.

What this means for you



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- **Talk to your clinician.** Personalised advice always beats blanket rules.
- **Track your symptoms.** Use a simple diary so you can spot patterns over weeks, not days.
- **Move within comfort.** Gentle, regular activity protects joints and mood.

- ****Watch the warning signs.**** New swelling, fever, or rapid loss of function deserve same-week review.
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Practical next steps

1. Read our companion piece for a deeper dive: [\[related guidance\]](#)[\(/conditions/rheumatoid-arthritis\)](#). 2. Bring three questions to your next GP or rheumatology appointment. 3. Share this article with a family member who supports you day to day.

Editorial standards



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This article was prepared by the Living With Arthritis Editorial Team from UK NICE guidance and peer-reviewed sources. Pending clinical review. We update content at least annually.

What the Evidence Says

The scientific evidence on managing arthritis during pregnancy strongly emphasises careful pre-conception planning. Systematic reviews highlight that while many disease-modifying anti-rheumatic drugs (DMARDs) can harm a developing baby, ongoing management of arthritis is crucial for the health of both parent and child. Uncontrolled inflammation itself can increase risks during pregnancy.

Clinical guidelines from leading UK professional bodies consistently recommend a multi-disciplinary approach. This involves close collaboration between rheumatologists, obstetricians, and specialist nurses to ensure medication adjustments are made safely. These guidelines are built upon a foundation of observational studies and expert consensus, given the ethical limitations of conducting randomised trials in pregnant populations.

Research also points to the benefits of non-pharmacological strategies. Regular, gentle exercise and other lifestyle interventions, such as nutrition and stress management, are shown to improve symptoms without posing risks to pregnancy. These strategies complement medication adjustments and are a key part of maintaining well-being.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

*** **Stopping medication abruptly:**** Never stop DMARDs or other arthritis medication without consulting your doctor; this can lead to a flare-up. Instead, discuss your pregnancy plans with your rheumatologist well in advance. *** **Assuming all pain is arthritis-related:**** Pregnancy brings its own aches and pains; don't assume every new symptom is your arthritis. Instead, track new symptoms and discuss them with your GP or midwife. *** **Neglecting pre-conception counselling:**** Waiting until you're pregnant to discuss medication changes can be risky. Instead, plan to have a detailed discussion about your arthritis and any medication with your rheumatologist before trying to conceive. *** **Ignoring mental health:**** Pregnancy with a chronic condition can be emotionally challenging. Instead, talk openly with your partner, family, and healthcare team about your feelings and ask for support if you need it. *** **Overdoing physical activity:**** While movement is good, pushing through significant pain can cause more harm. Instead, listen to your body and stick to gentle, low-impact activities recommended by a physiotherapist.

When to Speak to a Clinician

While careful planning helps manage arthritis during pregnancy, certain symptoms or situations require prompt medical attention. Your rheumatologist, GP, or midwife should be contacted if you experience any significant changes.

* Sudden, severe joint pain or swelling that doesn't ease with rest. * New or worsening fatigue that significantly impacts your daily life. * Any signs of infection, such as fever alongside joint pain. * Unexplained rash or skin changes. * Concerns about medication side effects or significant changes in your arthritis symptoms.

Frequently Asked Questions

Can I still breastfeed if I have arthritis and take medication? Many medications for arthritis are considered safe during breastfeeding, but others are not. It's really important to have an open discussion with your rheumatologist and GP about your breastfeeding plans so they can advise on the safest options for you and your baby.

How will pregnancy affect my arthritis symptoms? The effect of pregnancy on arthritis symptoms varies greatly from person to person. Some people find their symptoms improve during pregnancy, particularly in the second and third trimesters, while others experience no change or even a worsening of symptoms. Your rheumatologist will monitor your condition closely.

What specialist support is available during pregnancy for people with arthritis? You should expect to receive care from a multi-disciplinary team, including your rheumatologist, obstetrician, and specialist nurses. They will work together to manage your arthritis and pregnancy, providing tailored advice and monitoring throughout.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about pregnancy and arthritis: what uk guidelines recommend?

Short answer: Managing arthritis during pregnancy requires careful pre-conception planning due to many disease-modifying anti-rheumatic drugs (DMARDs) being unsafe. UK guidelines recommend a multidisciplinary approach involving rheumatologists, obstetricians, and specialist nurses to safely adjust medication. Non-pharmacological strategies like gentle exercise, nutrition, and stress management are also important for well-being.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk